

Masculinity Norms and Their Economic Consequences*

Ieda Matavelli[†] Pauline Grosjean[‡] Ralph De Haas[§] Victoria Baranov[¶]

Abstract

While economists have extensively studied gender norms affecting women, masculinity norms—the informal rules that guide and constrain the behaviors of boys and men—remain underexplored. This review first examines how other disciplines have studied masculinity, providing economists with conceptual foundations and empirical patterns for understanding masculinity norms. We then discuss how the study of masculinity norms can inform the economics literature on gender gaps and men’s outcomes across multiple domains: health behavior, labor supply and occupational choice, violence and aggression, and political preferences. We also discuss the paths for transmission and persistence of masculinity norms. Finally, using novel survey data from 70 countries, we present five stylized facts about masculinity norms. We document substantial global variation in these norms and demonstrate their predictive power for various socioeconomic and political outcomes.

Keywords: Masculinity norms; gender; cultural economics

*We thank Sofia Amaral, Ivan Balbuzanov, Cordelia Fine, Alex Frankel, and Joshua Miller for helpful comments. This manuscript was prepared for publication in the *Annual Review of Economics*.

[†]UNSW. E-mail: i.matavelli@unsw.edu.au.

[‡]UNSW and CEPR. E-mail: p.grosjean@unsw.edu.au.

[§]EBRD, KU Leuven and CEPR. E-mail: dehaasr@ebrd.com.

[¶]University of Melbourne and CEPR. E-mail: victoria.baranov@unimelb.edu.au.

1 Introduction

A rich economics literature shows how social norms guide and constrain the behaviors of women and girls, throughout their lifetime and across multiple domains.¹ In comparison, only a few papers in our discipline have studied, or even explicitly acknowledged, how social norms guide and constrain the behaviors of men and boys. One explanation for this asymmetry may well be that “to economists, the default agent in an economic model is male, so that masculine characteristics or behavior are seen as “human” characteristics or behavior” (Lundberg, 2024). However, as we document in this review, social norms also shape men’s lives, namely by prescribing what jobs, health behaviors and care provision, and political attitudes are deemed appropriate for them. This asymmetry in economics mirrors a pattern observed previously in other social sciences. Nearly 40 years ago, sociologists noted that “although numerous studies have investigated social attitudes toward the appropriate sex roles for women [...], considerably less research has examined public attitudes toward the male sex role” (Thompson Jr and Pleck, 1986). This realization spurred a rich literature in sociology, gender studies, and psychology that greatly advanced these disciplines’ understanding of masculinity norms and their consequences. We believe that economics now faces a similar reckoning.²

We define masculinity norms as the informal rules that guide and constrain men’s behaviors by shaping beliefs about appropriate conduct for men, potentially affecting both men’s and women’s lives. Our goal is to encourage economists to consider masculinity norms as one important driving factor (among many others) of economic decision making and gender gaps, not as a comprehensive explanation for all gender-related economic phenomena. We believe that economists are well equipped to advance this field through theoretical development, (quasi-) experimental analysis of the causes and consequences of masculinity norms, improved measurement across contexts, as well as evidence-based policy recommendations.

This review is structured as follows. In Section 2, we examine how other fields—evolutionary biology, anthropology, psychology, and sociology—study masculinity, providing economists with conceptual foundations and empirical patterns for understanding masculinity norms. Drawing on literature across these disciplines, we argue that masculinity norms are not simply the inverse of norms governing women’s roles but constitute a distinct set of beliefs about appropriate male conduct. Section 3 explores how incorporating masculinity norms can deepen our understanding of gender gaps and men’s outcomes in several domains, including labor market and household outcomes, health behaviors, educational choices, violence and aggression, and political populism. Section 4 draws on the cultural economics literature to highlight the mechanisms for the transmission and persistence of masculinity norms. In Section 5, we

¹For comprehensive reviews, see Giuliano (2020), Jayachandran (2015), and Anderson (2025).

²“Of the largest and institutionally most developed social science disciplines, economics has probably been the most reluctant to contribute to studies on men and masculinities, even though economy and economic considerations are absolutely fundamental aspects of gender relations and the gendering of men and masculinities.” (Kimmel et al., 2004, p. 4).

describe evidence from a new global survey of masculinity norms fielded by [De Haas et al. \(2025\)](#) in partnership with the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD) and the World Bank in 70 countries, analyzing both demographic variation in norm adherence and its predictive power for occupational choices, health outcomes, and political preferences. Section 6 concludes and sketches directions for future research on masculinity norms and their economic consequences.

2 Masculinity in other fields

We first discuss biological explanations for masculinity norms, then synthesize relevant findings from anthropology, sociology, and psychology. Space limitations preclude a comprehensive literature review, so we focus on insights most relevant to economic research.³

2.1 (Evolutionary) biology

Evolutionary biology seeks to uncover stable, universal, biologically driven explanations for the pervasiveness of sex-based behavioral differences, chief among which males' high competitive drive. Darwin's theory of sexual selection proposed that such behaviors evolve because they provide advantages in reproductive competition for mates ([Darwin, 1871](#)). In particular, Darwin observed that males typically compete more intensely than females because of their relatively lower costs of gamete production. Building on this insight, [Trivers \(1972\)](#) proposed that total parental investment (that is, not just the cost of gamete production but also of gestation, lactation, and offspring protection) determines competitive dynamics between the sexes. The sex with lower obligatory parental investment (typically, among mammals, males) can potentially maximize reproductive success through increased mating rather than parenting effort,⁴ helping explain why males often compete more intensely across species.

When applied to humans, this framework faces some challenges from anthropological research pointing to stable pair bonds and high levels of male provisioning ([Alger et al., 2020](#)). Nevertheless, males may compete intensively *prior* to forming stable pair bonds to accumulate status and resources.⁵ Male competitive behavior also evolved to include not just one-on-one contests but also group-based competition ([Henrich and Gil-White, 2001](#)). That is, men can pursue status through two main pathways: dominance-based competition based on physical force and prestige-based competition that showcases skills valued by the group. Rather than

³[Kimmel et al. \(2004\)](#) and [Levant and Wong \(2017\)](#) provide comprehensive reviews of the study of men and masculinities in the sociology and psychology fields.

⁴Although human males are often involved in provisioning and parenting, their effort is on average both lower and more variable than that of their female partners in most cultures ([Hrdy, 2011](#)).

⁵These insights have also recently begun to inform economic modeling; for example, [Alger \(2021\)](#) develops a theoretical framework in which male-male competition and male-female household formation represent sequential stages of an evolutionary matching process.

eliminating competitive drives, the shift from physical dominance to prestige-based status has channeled men's competitive instincts into economic success, career advancement, and wealth accumulation, explaining why masculine norms emphasizing competition remain prevalent in modern market economies (De Haas et al., 2025).

Some traits associated with masculinity—such as physical aggression and risk-taking—may have specific biological foundations (Lippa, 2016). Although testosterone is often seen as a key biological contributor to expressions of masculinity, meta-analyses have found only weak positive associations between testosterone and both aggression and risk-taking, with no evidence of a causal link (Geniole et al., 2020; Yuan et al., 2025).⁶ However, testosterone's relationship with behavior is complex and context-dependent, driving status-seeking behavior rather than simple aggression (Eisenegger et al., 2011; Carré and Mehta, 2018). Moreover, testosterone levels can be shaped by social roles and caring behaviors: men who spend time with babies or who become primary caregivers exhibit marked reductions in testosterone (Hrdy, 2024). Socialization also creates feedback loops between social behavior and endocrine function, as gender norms that encourage risk taking and competitiveness can lead men to engage in behaviors that increase testosterone (Van Anders et al., 2015). All of this challenges the simplistic view that testosterone causes masculinity; instead, testosterone production may be partly endogenous to gendered behavior and cultural expectations. There is, however, stronger evidence for testosterone's influence during the *in utero* period, where it may shape brain development—a concept known as brain organization theory (Bütikofer et al., 2019). According to this theory, testosterone acts as an organizational hormone, producing lasting changes in brain structure and function that affect responses to hormones and experiences later in life.

2.2 Anthropology

While evolutionary biology seeks to uncover and explain universal tendencies in masculine behavior, anthropological research offers a useful complementary perspective. Anthropologists typically view masculinity not merely as a biological endowment but as a set of culturally shaped practices and expectations. According to Gilmore (1990), cultures typically frame masculine adulthood not as an automatic biological transition but as a social achievement demanding proof through ritualized challenges. While boys are typically indoctrinated and tested before being recognized as men, women's transition to adulthood usually requires less cultural intervention.

⁶In economics, the effects of testosterone on financial decision making have been studied through observational data and controlled experiments. Coates and Herbert (2008) study male traders on a London trading floor, finding that morning testosterone levels predict daily profits, while cortisol levels rise with trading uncertainty and market volatility. Cueva et al. (2015) provide causal evidence through hormone administration experiments, showing that both cortisol and testosterone shift investment toward riskier assets, with testosterone operating by inducing increased optimism about future price changes. Sapienza et al. (2009) find that higher testosterone levels are associated with a lower aversion to financial risk among women in a sample of over 500 MBA students.

The anthropological perspective also challenges reductionist explanations of masculinity. Gilmore (1990) argues that masculinity cannot be reduced to either universal patriarchal exploitation (since manhood tests exist even in egalitarian societies like African Bushmen) or purely evolutionary drives (since many peaceful societies still emphasize masculine achievement). Instead, he argues that *“the answer to the manhood puzzle must lie in culture; we must try to understand why culture uses or exaggerates biological potentials in specific ways.”* This anthropological framework thus bridges the biological foundations discussed earlier with the social psychological approaches we examine next, which analyze masculinity as both individual identity and social institution.

2.3 Social psychology and sociology

Foundational theories. Although a biological perspective may help explain male competitive and dominance-seeking behavior across societies, it cannot account for the variation in how these tendencies are expressed, channeled, or suppressed. Social psychology and sociology have made important advances in this regard, developing both theory and measurement tools that capture the multidimensional nature of masculinity norms.

Within psychology, early research was dominated by the Male Sex Role Identity Paradigm, which treated masculinity as a stable psychological trait that men either possessed or lacked. Pleck (1981) critiqued this approach with the development of the Gender Role Strain Paradigm, which redefined masculinity as socially constructed and paved the way for research into how social forces shape masculine ideals into specific behavioral expectations that vary across time, place, and social groups.

Concurrently, sociologists developed the framework of hegemonic masculinity (Carrigan et al., 1985), defined as *“the configuration of practices that represents the most honored way of being a man in a given social context, distinguished from less respected masculinities and providing legitimacy for the overall subordination of women in society”* (Wedgwood et al., 2023). This framework emphasizes that masculine ideals are relational—defined not only in opposition to femininity but also in contrast to subordinated forms of masculinity, in particular racial or sexual minorities’ masculinities.⁷ These developments spurred a rich literature on men and masculinity in the social sciences.⁸

⁷Other terms such as ‘traditional masculinity’, ‘dominant’ or ‘dominance’ masculinity refer to related concepts and are often used interchangeably. Moreover, the term ‘masculinities’ is sometimes used to refer to multiple facets of masculinity across contexts, social class, race, ethnicity, sexual orientation, etc.

⁸In parallel, gender studies developed an even more flexible understanding of masculinity. Butler (1990)’s theory of gender performativity challenged the notion that gender naturally follows from sex, arguing instead that both are socially constructed through cultural practices. While Butler focused primarily on gender more generally, their ideas were later taken up in gender studies to emphasize how masculine identities are continuously enacted and thus open to disruption and change.

Measuring masculinity. Although psychologists and sociologists consider masculinity as socially constructed and malleable, cross-cultural research has revealed some remarkably consistent dimensions of masculine roles across societies (Gilmore, 1990). These include restrictive emotionality, self-reliance, aggression, dominance over women, a disdain for homosexuality, an emphasis on achievement and status, and avoidance of femininity (Levant and Fischer, 1998; Mahalik et al., 2003), a set of behaviors and ideals that align, in particular, with *hegemonic* masculinity norms. To measure these dimensions, psychologists have developed several scales, with the three most influential being the Bem Sex Role Inventory (BSRI) (Bem, 1981), the Male Role Norms Inventory (MRNI) (Levant and Fischer, 1998), and the Conformity to Masculinity Norms Inventory (CMNI) (Mahalik et al., 2003). These scales differ in their theoretical foundations. While the BSRI gauges an individual’s self-identification with predefined and socially constructed masculine (e.g. self-reliant), feminine (e.g. warm), or neutral (e.g. friendly) traits—that are not necessarily opposite to one another but more or less independent characteristics—the MRNI and CMNI focus on masculinity as socially prescribed norms and expectations. The MRNI measures agreement with normative beliefs across seven dimensions (e.g., “A man should never reveal worries to others”), whereas the CMNI assesses behavioral conformity to 11 dimensions of masculinity through statements such as “It bothers me to ask for help” and “Sometimes violent action is necessary.” Most recent empirical studies on men and masculinity use (variations of) either the CMNI or MRNI.⁹ In Section 5, we summarize evidence from data collection in 70 countries using a short form of the CMNI along with normative beliefs adapted from the MRNI used in De Haas et al. (2025).

Existing measures of masculinity developed in the psychology and sociology literatures often conflate personal preferences (i.e., “what I like”) with first-order normative beliefs (i.e., “what I think men should do”). Therefore, further contributions to the measurement of masculine identities and masculinity norms will have to account more carefully for personal preferences as distinct from first-order beliefs and additionally consider the roles of descriptive norms (i.e., beliefs about what other men actually do) and second-order beliefs (i.e., beliefs about what others think men should do).¹⁰

Key insights. A large literature in psychology and sociology documents robust relationships between men’s adherence to hegemonic masculinity norms (measured by the above scales) and outcomes in health, violence and aggression, and behavior in the workplace. We now provide

⁹Variations of these scales have been created to accommodate shorter forms, new masculinity dimensions, or different contexts. See Thompson Jr and Bennett (2015) for a review.

¹⁰Recent work in economics has developed a single item “Continuous Gender Identity” measure adapted from the psychology literature. This continuous approach to measuring gender identity predicts gender gaps in economic preferences, education, and labor market outcomes beyond the explanatory power of binary sex categories (Brenøe et al., 2024). While this measure captures how individuals position themselves on a gender continuum, it does not reveal what specific traits or behaviors constitute masculinity. It captures self-perceived gender identity, not gender-related norms.

a selective review of this empirical evidence.

First, in the health domain, a consistent finding is that men's adherence to masculinity norms predicts higher depression scores, suicidal ideation, and health-related problems, including alcoholism and drug overdoses (Mahalik and Rochlen, 2006; Wong et al., 2017). Men with stronger adherence to masculinity norms tend to stigmatize mental health problems (Mahalik et al., 2003). Rather than seeking help, these men often respond to depression through risk-taking behaviors such as substance abuse (Mahalik and Rochlen, 2006). This pattern contributes to systematic underuse of preventative health services (Mahalik and Rochlen, 2005).

Second, research in social psychology suggests that men engage in violence to establish and defend their social status and power. This not only serves to assert dominance over women but also to maintain hierarchical relationships among men themselves.¹¹ Such patterns reflect the broader concept of "precarious manhood": the idea that manhood is a social status that is difficult to achieve but easy to lose, requiring public performative displays to maintain it (Gilmore, 1990; Vandello et al., 2008). When men perceive threats to their masculinity, they often overcompensate by displaying exaggerated masculine behaviors. This is particularly evident in honor cultures, where masculine status must be earned and defended through displays of strength and willingness to retaliate (Cohen et al., 1996). Researchers have tested this theory in the lab by randomly assigning a condition to threaten men's masculine identity (for example, by providing feedback that they are less masculine than others). Consistent with the theory that manhood is precarious, several studies find that men whose masculinity is threatened become more aggressive and take greater risks (Vandello and Bosson, 2013). An example from economics is D'Acunto (2020), who conducts on-line experiments to show that men whose gender identity is threatened (or primed), increase their investment in risky opportunities and become overconfident even in pure games of chance. Effects are larger for older men and those in regions with more traditional gender norms, suggesting that men take greater risks not because they rationally assess better odds, but because they psychologically inflate their chances of success to preserve their sense of masculinity.

Third, research in organizational sociology has identified masculinity contest cultures: environments that reward masculine behaviors over actual performance. Work then becomes an arena for proving manhood because it enables men to acquire resources (money, power, status) for dominance. Although these cultures may *appear* merit-based, they systematically disadvantage women and other underrepresented groups both by defining merit standards around traits predominantly held by dominant men, or by punishing members of outgroups for displaying those traits — for example, assertiveness, ambition and self-promotion (Brescoll and Uhlmann, 2008). Empirical evidence links masculinity contests to toxic leadership, reduced psychological

¹¹Sociological perspectives similarly emphasize that masculinity is not a stable trait, but a status that must be repeatedly demonstrated and defended, producing hierarchies both among men and between men and women (Connell and Messerschmidt, 2005).

safety, and higher staff turnover, indicating organizational dysfunction that prioritizes status competition over productive outcomes (Berdahl et al., 2018).

Last, rigid notions of traditional masculinity may interact with broader economic transformations. The decline of heavy industry, mining, and manufacturing, and the increase in service employment has contributed to the “feminization” of the workforce, eroding traditional breadwinner roles that provided economic security and masculine identity (Kimmel, 2012). Such economic shifts can create threats to core male roles: Michniewicz et al. (2014) show that men fear being viewed as “less manly” after a job loss. And while there is limited quantitative work linking masculinity norms with political attitudes and work-related outcomes, recent qualitative studies in sociology discuss possible links between threatened masculinity due to employment shocks and support for populism. In Section 3.7, we discuss in more detail how masculinity norms can shape political reactions to economic upheaval.

3 Masculinity norms in economics

Although few economists have explicitly acknowledged it, several strands of the economics literature can be connected to masculinity norms and their economic, social, and political impacts. In this section, we focus on key contributions where gender gaps have been widely documented and discuss how considering masculinity norms can enrich our understanding of the origins and manifestations of these gaps, as well as inform the design of policy interventions.

3.1 Theoretical frameworks

We briefly review theoretical frameworks relevant to understanding how masculinity norms can shape behavior. As a particular set of social norms, masculinity norms can be defined as shared beliefs about what individuals of a particular social category (in this case, men) typically do (descriptive norms) or ought to do (injunctive norms) (Bicchieri, 2017). In general terms, social norms provide a mapping between a social category and expected behavior, which then influences individuals’ decision-making. How this mapping operates depends on the specific mechanisms through which social influences are modeled.

A range of theoretical work in economics has considered situations where individual behavior is motivated by social factors, such as the desire for conformity (Bernheim, 1994) or group-think (Akerlof, 2016), identity or self-image (Akerlof and Kranton, 2000), avoidance of social sanctions (Fehr and Gächter, 2002), and social-image concerns (Bénabou and Tirole, 2006). For example, in the self-image framework, norms are internalized as preferences.¹² A person who

¹²Norms are considered internalized when individuals incorporate them into their personal value systems, resulting in automatic or habitual compliance independent of external incentives or sanctions. During social change, it is possible to observe a disconnect between internalized norms, which are deeply ingrained, and changing social norms—a phenomenon that may generate anxiety and cognitive dissonance.

identifies as a ‘manly’ man then gets greater utility from actions that, according to masculinity norms, are aligned with a male identity.¹³ By contrast, in the social-image framework, individuals use their actions to signal membership to a desired group (such as ‘manly’ men), which may give them access to resources (instrumental motives) or social status (hedonic motives). Here the norms determine others’ beliefs about his group/type as a function of his behavior.¹⁴ These two frameworks differ in their predictions: in the social-image framework, behaviors change when they are observable to others, while in the self-image framework the observability is inconsequential.¹⁵ Finally, beyond explicit social motivations, norms can also be thought of in terms of equilibria in a coordination game (Young, 2015). For instance, in certain settings, the best response for men may be to be aggressive towards other men if they expect others to be aggressive, and friendly if they expect others to be friendly.

3.2 Labor markets and organizations

Despite the considerable progress of women in terms of labor force participation and earnings in the second half of the twentieth century, substantial gender earnings gaps remain, at levels remarkably stable since the 1990s (Goldin, 2021; Grosjean, 2021).¹⁶ Women remain over-represented in lower-paying occupations and continue to face barriers to the most lucrative positions.

Occupational sorting. The systematic sorting of women and men across occupations and industries is a key determinant of persistent gender wage gaps. Gender differences in occupation and industry choice explained 20 percentage points of the average pay gap in the 1980s, and explain more than half of it today (Blau and Kahn, 2017). Even within occupation and industry, gender sorting across firms is correlated with significant earnings gaps, with women sorting into smaller and lower-paying firms, and appropriating a smaller share of the firm-specific surplus than men (Card et al., 2016; Kleven et al., 2019). Gender gaps in negotiation over promotions and pays have been widely documented, too (see, e.g., Recalde and Vesterlund 2023).

While several papers have empirically established that social norms about women’s roles—particularly norms about domestic responsibilities and relative earnings—are key determinants of gender gaps in labor market outcomes (see, e.g., Bertrand et al. 2015; Folke and Rickne 2020; Hancock et al. 2025), the potential role of masculinity norms for occupational sorting — and ultimately employment and growth— have become particularly salient following re-

¹³The identity framework of Akerlof and Kranton (2000) is more flexible in the definition of identity, allowing even a social-image motivation: “Since an individual’s self-concept may be formed by seeing oneself through the eyes of others ..., these gains or losses may also depend on how others interpret i’s actions.” Here we take a more simplified interpretation of the models so as to draw out the main distinctions between them.

¹⁴Additionally, norms may also determine the social value or esteem of group membership.

¹⁵See Bursztyn and Jensen (2017) for a more in-depth discussion and review.

¹⁶Even the recent convergence in earnings observed in some advanced economies since the COVID pandemic partly reflects men’s retreat from the labor force rather than women’s advancement. This trend began in the early 2000s and has been linked to falling prices of leisure activities, particularly video gaming (Aguiar et al., 2021).

cent waves of technological progress and globalization, which have disproportionately affected male employment (Autor et al., 2019). Many newly unemployed men have remained unemployed or left the labor force, despite growth in service sector jobs. This behavior is consistent with rigid masculinity norms that promote inflexible notions of what constitutes a “real” man and a “real” job. Such beliefs assign social value to occupations based on their gender composition, systematically devaluing female-dominated sectors (Goldin, 2014). The presence of women often dilutes occupational prestige and reduces the identity-based payoffs for men, who may prefer to switch occupations or, absent suitable alternatives, remain unemployed (Pan, 2015). Consequently, men often refuse service sector jobs that conflict with their masculine identity or are perceived as feminine (Akerlof and Kranton, 2000; Delfino, 2024).

Tariffs. The consequences of appeals to masculine identity can be far-reaching. For example, in recent debates about US trade policy, protectionism has been framed not only as an economic strategy, but also as a defense of traditional masculinity. Proponents of tariffs as a means to revive manufacturing industries have invoked a narrative in which factory work represents “real manhood” while portraying service sector employment as emasculating.

Masculinity contest cultures. Beyond occupational sorting, masculinity norms also shape workplace dynamics *within* organizations and can contribute to the stagnation of women’s economic progress. Gender differences in willingness to work long or inflexible hours have been identified as a main contributor to persistent gender inequality and the glass ceiling (Goldin, 2021). While motherhood and care obligations partially explain these differences, economists acknowledge that “*our understanding of the precise sources of the returns to long/inflexible working hours is limited*” (Olivetti et al., 2024).

The sociological literature on masculinity contest cultures offers valuable insights here. These cultures enforce dominance masculinity norms within organizations, promoting zero-sum competition played according to rules defined by masculine norms (such as displaying strength, showing no weakness or doubt, valuing work over all else) (Berdahl et al., 2018). They systematically valorize masculine qualities, devalue feminine traits and exclude racial and sexual minorities from networks, workplace interactions, and positions of power.

Recent economic research demonstrates this dynamic: smoking interactions that systematically favor men explain up to one-third of the gender gap in promotions (Cullen and Perez-Truglia, 2023). Follow-up work examines social drinking as another domain of exclusionary male culture (Kitagawa et al., 2025). Academia also provides a revealing case study, as it embodies core elements of masculinity contest cultures: hypercompetitive norms, hierarchical structures that divide an elite of “those who have what it takes to succeed” from others, and the valorization of work over personal life. Guadalupe et al. (2025) finds that masculinity contest cultures in this setting not only harm employee well-being but also reduce productivity—both quantity and quality—across all organizational members, even those at the “top”.

Masculinity contest cultures also prove inhospitable to work-family balance, further disadvantaging women and discouraging men from taking paternity leave. They can also foster harassment and are associated with tendencies to resent women's advancement, which is seen as taking away from men in zero-sum competition (Berdahl et al., 2018). These workplace dynamics may contribute to systematic and persistent child penalties in the labor market—that is, worse trajectories in labor market outcomes for mothers than fathers (Kleven et al., 2024). They may also explain the relative failure of gender-neutral parental leave policies in attenuating child penalties (Olivetti and Petrongolo, 2017). The take-up of paternity leave remains low compared to maternity leave, even where policies are available.¹⁷

Masculinity contests can contribute to this low take-up by imposing social sanctions on men who deviate from expected behaviors. Using a survey experiment and large-scale audit study, Weisshaar (2018) finds that fathers face higher penalties when they take time off for family care relative to mothers, especially in tight labor markets, due to violations of “ideal worker” norms that are more rigidly applied to men than to women. These results suggest that understanding how masculinity norms around fatherhood at individual and organizational levels impact child penalties represents an important avenue for future research.

Competitiveness. A substantial literature identifies gender differences in competitiveness and confidence as key drivers of occupational sorting and gender pay gaps (Niederle and Vesterlund, 2011). Existing evidence suggests that gender differences in competitiveness reflect broader social structures rather than innate preferences (Gneezy et al., 2009; Cassar and Zhang, 2022). Given that competitiveness is a core masculinity norm, the lack of systematic research on how masculinity norms shape these gaps is surprising. In recent work, we find that gender differences in adherence to masculinity norms explain 23% of the gender gap in competitiveness in a global sample of more than 70,000 respondents (De Haas et al., 2025).

Other work indicates that individuals' willingness to compete also depends on the proportion of men relative to women in peer groups. Evidence from studies exploiting variation in male-biased sex ratios—due to historical convict transportation to Australia (Baranov et al., 2023) or the random assignment to university accommodation (Delavande et al., 2024) and Army boot camps (Dahl et al., 2021)—shows that greater exposure to male peers predicts higher male competitiveness. These findings underline that masculinity norms are an important, though underexplored, mechanism linking social environments to gender gaps in economic outcomes.

3.3 Household outcomes

Household bargaining. An extensive economics literature has established the influence of social norms about women's roles on marriage formation, marital satisfaction, household bar-

¹⁷See OECD Blog, 12-01-2023.

gaining, and the division of home production. A seminal study by [Bertrand et al. \(2015\)](#) shows that households systematically “avoid” matches in which female earnings exceed male ones. Moreover, women compensate by increasing their labor supply at home, even when they earn more and work more hours in the labor market than their male partners ([Hancock et al., 2025](#)). These patterns have real consequences: female promotion and higher earnings predict lower marital satisfaction and increased divorce rates ([Folke and Rickne, 2020](#)). Moreover, despite significant advances in women’s career opportunities and earnings over recent decades, the gendered allocation of housework has proven highly resistant to change ([Hancock et al., 2025](#)). Worldwide, women continue to spend two to ten times more time on unpaid care work, including housework, than men ([Ferrant et al., 2014](#)).

So far, these findings have been interpreted through the lens of rigid cultural norms prescribing women’s domestic responsibilities and earnings relative to men. Yet, although perhaps not explicitly, several studies also suggest a potentially large role for masculinity norms. In particular, husbands’ social image concerns have been highlighted as major drivers of female labor force participation, often overriding personal beliefs about male and female responsibilities about domestic and labor market work ([Bernhardt et al. 2018](#); [Bursztyn et al. 2020](#); [Abou Daher et al. 2025](#)).

Economic shocks. Considering masculinity norms can also enrich our understanding of the broader social implications of the China import competition shock. Rising international manufacturing competition during 1990–2014 disproportionately reduced employment opportunities for young men in the U.S. [Autor et al. \(2019\)](#) study how these gender-specific economic shocks affected marriage, fertility, and children’s living circumstances. They find that negative shocks to male relative earnings have reduced marriage and fertility, which is consistent with Becker’s model of household specialization. Yet, these shocks have also increased male idleness and mortality from drug and alcohol abuse as well as raised the share of unwed mothers. We have already discussed how rigid masculinity norms may have contributed to male idleness by preventing men from taking up jobs that did not fit their masculine gender identity.

The rise in unwed motherhood presents a puzzling pattern that traditional economic models struggle to explain. Typically, increases in out-of-wedlock births reflect *higher* male bargaining power in relationships, yet this occurred precisely when men experienced negative economic shocks that should have *reduced* their bargaining power.

Theories of precarious manhood offer a compelling explanation for this puzzle. Because employment—particularly in certain types of “masculine” work—is tightly connected to male social status, unemployment represents an especially severe threat to men’s identity. Job loss means losing not only income, but also self-worth and social standing as men ([Bosson et al., 2009](#)). With their masculinity threatened, men often engage in compensatory behaviors such as increased aggression and risk-taking to restore their status. They may also turn to substance

abuse as a coping mechanism for the anxiety and stress that accompany both unemployment and threats to their gender identity. These maladaptive responses can make men emotionally unavailable or even abusive in relationships.

Parenting. The household patterns documented above—where women continue to bear disproportionate responsibility for domestic work despite significant advances in their career opportunities and earnings—extend to perhaps the most consequential domain of household production: parenting. The vast economics literature measuring time, monetary, and emotional parental investment has almost exclusively studied maternal contributions.¹⁸ The few studies measuring fathers’ time investment in children document substantially lower paternal investment compared with maternal investment, even among dual-earner households where both parents work full-time (Aguiar and Hurst, 2007; Buzard et al., 2025; Walker et al., 2025). This disparity persists despite evidence that fathers’ time inputs are nearly as productive as mothers’ time inputs for child development (Del Boca et al., 2014).

Masculinity norms can shape fatherhood through both preference formation and social expectations around gendered parenting styles (Pleck, 2010). In many cultures, expectations of fatherhood remain anchored in traditional gender roles that prescribe men as breadwinners while limiting their emotional involvement with children. These expectations are reinforced by core masculinity norms emphasizing emotional stoicism and self-reliance, which constrain how fathers interact with and invest in their children (Petts et al., 2018). Empirical evidence supports this connection: adherence to traditional masculinity norms as measured by the CMNI strongly predicts fathers’ level of engagement and discipline style with their children (Petts et al., 2018). Given the influence of parenting styles on cognitive and non-cognitive skills formation, the influence of masculinity norms on paternal investments and parenting styles can have profound economic consequences.

3.4 Health

Men face substantial disadvantages in several preventable health behaviors and outcomes. Gender gaps in deaths from drugs, suicide, and alcohol—the so-called “deaths of despair” (Case and Deaton, 2020)—are widespread globally, with men three times more likely to die from these causes than women (Shirzad et al., 2024). This relative burden is also reflected in life expectancy: globally, men live on average five years less than women (GBD 2013, 2015).¹⁹

¹⁸Recent exceptions include Del Boca et al. (2014), Dizon-Ross and Jayachandran (2022) and Walker et al. (2025) as well as studies on paternity leave and work flexibility policies, including Farre et al. (2023) and references therein.

¹⁹At the same time, there are specific medical issues that disproportionately affect women. Moreover, medicine on average has been viewed through a supposedly gender-neutral lens which in reality may disadvantage women, as medical research and treatment protocols have historically been developed primarily based on male subjects and experiences. These are real and important issues that deserve attention. However, they do not negate the fact that men also suffer from gender-specific health issues, such as deaths of despair, which are influenced by

Incorporating a masculinity norms perspective into research on men's health offers a valuable path for advancing our understanding of the drivers of men's health behaviors, the conditions under which men seek or avoid help, and how masculinity norms shape stigma.

Health gender gaps. In economics, emerging research indicates that masculinity norms may help explain health gender gaps. [Schünemann et al. \(2017\)](#) perform a counterfactual analysis, endowing women with men's preferences—making women less risk averse and valuing less a healthy state—and show that these preferences can explain 70% of the gender gap in longevity. The underlying sources of these preference differences may themselves reflect internalized masculinity norms around risk taking and emotional expression. Previous work has established a link between masculinity norms and male health (particularly mental health), risk taking, and underinvestment in preventative health measures, including COVID vaccination ([Baranov et al., 2023](#)).

Help-seeking behaviors. Gendered health disparities partly reflect systematic differences in how men and women approach health care. The study of health outcomes through a masculinity lens is well-established in the public health, clinical, and social psychology literature, with extensive research documenting how restrictive masculinity norms contribute to men's health outcomes and gender gaps in this domain ([Fleming and Agnew-Brune, 2015](#)). Clinical research shows that many men struggle to seek mental and physical healthcare due to restrictive masculinity norms ([Addis and Mahalik, 2003](#)). [Addis and Mahalik \(2003\)](#) explain that help-seeking tasks—such as relying on others, admitting need for help, or recognizing emotional problems—often conflict with masculine ideals of self-reliance, toughness, and emotional control. This creates a fundamental tension where seeking help threatens masculine identity, normalizing help-avoidance behaviors. Healthcare delivery can reinforce these barriers. For example, traditional talk therapy often fails to engage men effectively, leading to higher dropout rates ([Seidler et al., 2018](#)).

Depression measurement. Despite men being considerably more likely than women to die from suicide, they are less likely to be diagnosed with depression as measured by standard scales such as the Patient Health Questionnaire ([Salk et al., 2017](#)). Because masculinity norms emphasize emotional control and self-reliance, men are less likely than women to recognize and report symptoms of emotional distress commonly assessed in standard measures (e.g., “feeling down, depressed or hopeless”). Hence, standard measures of depression likely underestimate the true prevalence among men. Instead of internalizing symptoms, depression in men often manifests through behaviors usually not captured in standard depression scales, such as engaging in risky behaviors related to substance abuse and violence ([Cavanagh et al., 2017](#)). To address the methodological caveats, psychometric scales specifically designed to measure depression among men have been developed, including measures that incorporate such exter-

masculinity norms and merit investigation.

nalized risk behaviors (e.g., [Rice et al. 2013](#)). These alternative assessment approaches suggest that gender differences in depression may be substantially smaller than traditional measures indicate.

Health impacts of economic displacement. A separate stream of economics literature focuses on the impact of job displacement on men. This work reveals that the relationship between economic stress and health outcomes also operates differently for men and women and does so in ways consistent with masculine role expectations. [Amorim et al. \(2023\)](#) finds that displaced men, but not women, have worse health outcomes, measured by hospitalizations and deaths. Importantly, income shocks alone cannot explain these gender gaps. Instead, stress-related conditions and disorders related to substance abuse explain half of these effects for men. External causes such as injuries, accidents, and assault account for the other half. These factors represent direct manifestations of masculinity norms related to restrictive emotionality and risk taking, suggesting that these norms shape how men respond to economic adversity through health-damaging behaviors. Related work explores the health consequences of the China import competition shock. Several papers document increases in male mortality from substance abuse, healthcare (under)utilization, and mental distress—both in the US and the UK ([Autor et al., 2019](#); [Adda and Fawaz, 2020](#)). These patterns are consistent with men turning to substance use and avoiding help-seeking when their traditional role as breadwinners—and thus their masculine identity—is threatened.

3.5 Education

Gender gaps favoring boys. Extensive research in economics has examined girls' underperformance in math and women's low participation in STEM.²⁰ [Fryer Jr and Levitt \(2010\)](#) provide compelling evidence that standard explanations—such as reduced investment by girls in math, lower parental expectations for girls in mathematics, and gender-biased testing—do not adequately explain these performance gaps. Instead, their country-level analysis suggests that broader gender inequality and restrictive gender norms toward women drive gender gaps in mathematical achievement. This cultural explanation finds further support in [Nollenberger et al. \(2016\)](#) and [Dossi et al. \(2021\)](#), who show that the math gender gap is related to gender equality in origin countries among migrants and is larger among whites in the US. Masculinity norms also contribute to these educational disparities: since competitiveness represents a core masculine trait, gender differences in competitive preferences help explain math achievement gaps and gendered patterns in STEM-related subject choices ([Buser et al., 2014](#)).

Gender gaps favoring girls. While much attention has focused on girls' underperformance in mathematics, masculinity norms also help explain the opposite pattern: boys' underperformance in other academic domains. These gender educational differences become particularly

²⁰See, for example, [Niederle and Vesterlund \(2010\)](#).

pronounced during adolescence, when boys face pressure to “man up” and conform to masculine ideals. During this developmental stage, rejecting school values by avoiding behaviors perceived as feminine—such as demonstrating academic effort and conscientiousness—becomes a strategy for asserting masculinity. This dynamic suggests that social image concerns may drive boys to systematically underinvest in education relative to girls as they seek to maintain a masculine persona. [Bursztyn et al. \(2018\)](#) provide evidence for this mechanism, demonstrating that students strategically reduce participation in educational activities when they anticipate peer pressure that stigmatizes academic effort. Their findings reveal context-dependent norms: in high-achieving environments, it is “cool to be smart”, whereas in settings where achievement faces social sanctions, it becomes “smart to be cool” by concealing effort. Although their analysis does not examine gender differences, boys may be particularly vulnerable to these social pressures during adolescence, when masculine identity formation becomes especially salient.

Previous work has studied how culture shapes gender gaps in math—which favor boys—but less research explores determinants of gender gaps that favor girls. Boys underperform girls in reading and writing, invest less time and effort in schoolwork, and express more negative attitudes toward school ([OECD, 2019](#)). [Lundberg \(2020\)](#) shows that socioeconomic status and cognitive skills cannot explain these gender gaps. Instead, differences in behavioral outcomes and, to a larger extent, aspirations appear to be the main drivers. Lundberg concludes that masculinity norms that discourage academic achievement are a potential driver of boys’ underperformance. [Fortin et al. \(2015\)](#) also shows that girls’ GPA have improved over the years, whereas boys’ have stagnated. They find that gender differences in expectations for attending higher education explain these increased gender gaps. These differential expectations translate into realized outcomes: women currently comprise the majority of college graduates ([Goldin et al., 2006](#)). Although economic factors may contribute to this trend—men face higher opportunity costs of education given their higher potential earnings across most occupations—masculinity norms may also play an important role in shaping boys’ educational disengagement. Understanding how specific aspects of masculinity norms, particularly those related to competitiveness, risk taking, and avoidance of femininity, influence men’s educational choices remains an important area for future research.

3.6 Violent behavior

Not only are men more likely than women to take their own lives across all age groups, but men and boys also engage in more physical and verbal aggression ([Campbell, 2007](#)). For example, men commit almost all homicides in the world and account for 81% of the world’s homicide victims ([UNODC, 2019](#)).

Competition and dominance. Violence is intimately related to competition and dominance—core elements of masculinity norms. These violent tendencies typically emerge in contexts

of scarcity and intense competition over resources, status, and mates. Studies document that unmarried men, who face the most intense competition for access to females, exhibit significantly higher rates of criminal behavior, including rape, murder, and assault (Henrich et al., 2012).

This competition-violence nexus extends beyond individual behavior to broader social dynamics. The influx of male migrants and associated mating competition has been linked to rising anti-refugee violence and hate crimes in Germany, particularly in areas with deteriorating employment conditions (Dancygier et al., 2022). Economic pressures more generally appear to trigger similar responses: trade liberalization and increased international competition have been associated with higher crime rates (Dix-Carneiro et al., 2018), such as following the China trade shock in the US (Che et al., 2018). These patterns align with theories of precarious manhood, suggesting that threats to traditional masculine roles—whether through mating competition or economic displacement—can manifest as increased aggression and violence.

Cultures of honor. Violence can also arise from the need to build a reputation for retaliation and revenge to deter theft in the context of economic precariousness and weak formal institutions. So-called cultures of honor, which rely heavily on aggression and male honor, are common adaptations among populations whose economic means of livelihoods can easily be stolen—such as herds of animals—and that live in stateless regions (Grosjean, 2014; Cao et al., 2021). Cultures of honor are patricentric cultures that are also associated with obsessions with women’s chastity and paternal certainty (Becker, 2025) and often entail violent punishment of women that escape control.

War and military service. The relationship between conflict and masculinity operates bidirectionally, with each reinforcing the other. Baranov et al. (2023) show that men from areas with historically male-biased sex ratios—areas that had developed heightened masculinity norms—were significantly more likely to volunteer for service in WWI. Masculinity norms served as a powerful driver of enlistment, with unenlisted young men facing public sanctions and shame for their perceived departure from idealized standards of masculinity and accusations of cowardice (Becker, 2021).

Military service, in turn, systematically reinforces and amplifies masculinity norms. Studies leveraging natural experiments such as draft lotteries—which circumvent selection bias into military service—document how conscription transforms men in ways that extend far beyond combat training. Military service renders men more authoritarian, more belligerent, more likely to justify violence as a solution to conflicts, more supportive of coups against civilian governments, and less tolerant of out-groups (Ertola Navajas et al., 2022). These effects manifest themselves in civilian life as well: Galiani et al. (2011) find that conscription increases the likelihood of developing a criminal record, while Autor et al. (2011) document elevated rates of mental distress and Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder among Vietnam veterans. Perhaps most

strikingly, [Cagé et al. \(2023\)](#) use the arbitrary rotation of French infantry regiments across battles and generals in WWI to show how military heroism and loyalty to commanders predicted the later renouncement of democratic values and collaboration with Nazi Germany in WWII. These transformations appear to originate in hierarchies of dominance and male-dominated environments rather than in exposure to violence per se ([Dahl et al., 2021](#); [Cagé et al., 2023](#)).

Violence against women. Masculinity norms may play a central role in shaping intimate partner violence (IPV) and other forms of violence against women (VAW). Norms that valorize emotional stoicism and legitimize violence can help explain why some men resort to violence as a means of expressing emotions. Early empirical work often interpret IPV as arising from a male “taste” for violence ([Aizer, 2010](#)) or as impulsive reactions shaped by “visceral factors” ([Card and Dahl, 2011](#)). In contrast, theoretical literature has long acknowledged that IPV may arise from multiple motivations, including instrumental goals—such as exerting control over resources—and status concerns triggered by perceived threats to male authority.²¹

Recent studies have documented a high prevalence and economic costs of VAW in both the workplace and in public spaces ([Adams-Prassl et al., 2024](#); [Amaral et al., 2025](#)). Masculinity norms may contribute to VAW in these environments through social image concerns—specifically, men’s concerns about appearing “manly” to other men. [Sharma \(2023\)](#) provides evidence for this mechanism, demonstrating that anti-sexual harassment training for men reduces sexual harassment in college settings primarily through men’s increased perception of social disapproval by other men rather than through changes in their intrinsic attitudes towards sexual harassment.

Masculinity norms related to male dominance also emerge as a key factor in explaining VAW in extreme contexts such as war zones. [Guarnieri and Tur-Prats \(2023\)](#) establish a link between masculinity cultures and the use of sexual violence in warfare, demonstrating that sexual violence in conflict is characteristic of groups with stronger norms of male dominance relative to their opponents. This suggests that sexual violence serves not only as a weapon of war, but also as an expression of masculine hierarchies between competing groups.

Violence prevention. Violence prevention interventions increasingly focus on the psychological drivers of violent behavior, particularly non-cognitive skills and preferences such as self-control and identity formation. A growing literature evaluates cognitive behavioral therapy for high-risk men ([Heller et al., 2017](#); [Blattman et al., 2017](#)). [Heller et al. \(2017\)](#) assess Chicago’s *Becoming a Man* program, which incorporates discussions about masculinity alongside other interventions. Although the program demonstrated significant reductions in violent crime and improvements in school participation, the masculinity component cannot be evaluated in isolation from other program elements. Similarly, [Shah et al. \(2023\)](#) find that a soccer-based inter-

²¹See [Baranov et al. \(2021\)](#) for a review of these and other motivations, their representation in economic models, and empirical evidence from randomized evaluations of cash transfer programs.

vention educating adolescent boys on sexual health, masculinity, and gender-based violence significantly reduces IPV. Although these studies engage with masculinity concepts, they typically do not explicitly measure masculinity norms or isolate their specific effects. Moreover, significant gaps remain in our understanding of effective interventions. Most existing studies focus primarily on gender-based violence, delivering limited knowledge about how masculinity norms determine men's engagement in violence against other men. This represents an important avenue for future research, particularly given that male-on-male violence constitutes the majority of violent crimes worldwide.

3.7 Politics

Recent commentary highlights growing gender gaps in the support for democratic and liberal values, particularly among younger generations.²² Men are more likely to vote for populist leaders and show greater support to strongman leadership than women (Spierings and Zaslave, 2017; De Haas et al., 2025). In addition, men occupy most political offices across all levels of the political system (Paxton and Hughes, 2017). Masculinity norms may play an important role in explaining both demand and supply side factors that explain these gender gaps.

Demand side. Inglehart and Norris (2019) argue that cultural backlash, often mediated by raw emotional reactions, is a potent force to explain the rise and electoral success of populism in recent years. According to this theory, traditionally dominant groups—particularly white men—feel threatened by decades of progressive social change including women's empowerment, minority rights, and cultural globalization, leading them to support populist leaders who promise to resist liberal values and political correctness. The connection between deindustrialization and cultural reaction, primarily among “angry white men”, may explain why only economic crises that have disproportionately affected traditional *male* employment have been linked to the rise of right-wing populism (Kimmel, 2017). This pattern of cultural backlash, particularly among men, suggests that threats to traditional masculine identity may be a key mechanism linking economic disruption to political change. By comparison, recent research suggests that recessions that had greater economic impacts on women rather than men, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, eroded the support for populist parties (Klassen, 2022).

Further evidence points to a direct connection between masculinity norms and right-wing politics. The online media environment, particularly for young men, is increasingly prone to content glorifying hegemonic masculinity norms and resenting the socio-economic inclusion and economic progress of women and sexual minorities, echoing far-right political leaders (Barker et al., 2023). Additionally, individual endorsement of hegemonic masculinity (measured by the CMNI scale) predicts support for U.S. President Trump, even when controlling for political party affiliation (Vescio and Schermerhorn, 2021).

²²E.g., Financial Times (26-01-2024).

Supply side. The supply side of political competition also reveals patterns in which masculinity norms can determine candidate selection. In recent years, manhood has been at the center of many political campaigns, and various candidates have strategically represented masculine ideals while trying to emasculate their opponents (Katz, 2016). In addition, the contemporary political arena often operates as a masculinity contest culture, preventing women from entering and succeeding in politics. Behaviors considered feminine, such as the use of “emotional” language in political discourse, is more common among groups less empowered in politics, including women (Gennaro and Ash, 2022).

4 Origins, persistence, and evolution of masculinity norms

Just as historical circumstances have shaped gender norms that guide women’s behavior (Giuliano, 2018), masculinity norms may have similar historical origins. Baranov et al. (2023) demonstrate one such example through their study of convict-era Australia, where historically male-biased sex ratios created a shortage of women and intensified competition among men. These conditions produced enduring changes to masculinity norms that persist today in the form of greater opposition to same-sex marriage, higher rates of violence and suicide, and increased occupational gender segregation. While this study provides important initial evidence, more research is needed to understand the full scope of historical influences on masculinity norms across different contexts.

Regardless of their historical origins, once established, masculinity norms demonstrate remarkable persistence across time. Understanding how these historically-rooted masculinity norms persist, requires examining the multiple mechanisms through which they are transmitted and reinforced. This section describes four key pathways: institutional channels that formalize masculine identity and norms through rituals and organizational structures, horizontal transmission through peer interactions, vertical transmission from parents to children across generations, and the role of misperceptions that can perpetuate norms even when individual beliefs may be shifting.

Institutional channels. Anthropologists have documented formal rituals involving violent, painful, or dangerous physical challenges used to signify the passage into manhood in diverse pre-industrial cultures around the world (Gilmore, 1990). Very similar patterns appear in modern organizational life: factories, elite schools, and the military all use similar socialization processes—physical challenges, hierarchy, and group loyalty—to perpetuate masculinity norms. Criminal organizations exemplify this through rites of passage that bind young men to the group while glorifying violence and toughness (Vigil, 1996). The military operates similarly, enforcing masculine codes through hierarchical structures and ritualized initiation.

Horizontal transmission. Beyond formal rituals and institutions, informal socialization within organizations also creates dominance hierarchies based on masculinity norms. Schools repre-

sent a particularly important social environment because peer interactions during childhood and adolescence are a major influence on the development of gender normative behavior. Baranov et al. (2023) document higher rates of bullying, specifically and exclusively among boys, in areas of Australia with historically more male biased sex ratios. They interpret these results as both a manifestation and a persistence mechanism of masculinity norms.

Vertical transmission. While socialization in schools shapes masculinity norms within peer groups, another important pathway of transmission operates across generations (Agostinelli et al., 2025). Baranov et al. (2023) also provide compelling evidence for vertical transmission by showing that historically male-skewed sex ratios continue to influence contemporary attitudes more among Australian-born individuals compared to foreign-born residents.

Misperceived norms and persistence. When people misperceive others' views, they may act against their own beliefs just to conform to the perceived norm (Bursztyn et al., 2020). In the context of masculinity norms, overestimating others' beliefs can perpetuate harmful behaviors. For example, men may avoid help seeking or use violence if they incorrectly think that is what others expect them to do. Matavelli (2025) documents that adolescent boys and girls systematically overestimate their peers' agreement with masculinity norms. Through field experiments with middle school students, she finds that brief discussions about masculinity reduce these misperceptions by approximately 50%. The study reveals that adolescents avoid these conversations because they underestimate how interesting such discussions will be, creating a cycle in which incorrect expectations prevent the very conversations that would correct misperceptions. This suggests that creating structured opportunities for boys to discuss masculinity during early adolescence—when these beliefs are still forming—may help prevent the solidification of misperceptions and break the cycle that sustains restrictive masculine norms.

Evolution of masculinity norms. While transmission and persistence mechanisms explain how masculinity norms endure, understanding how these norms change over time is equally important. Gender norms that constrain women have evolved considerably in recent decades (Goldin, 2024), but changes in masculinity norms remain less well documented, largely due to limited systematic measurement. Nevertheless, Connor et al. (2021) identify four emerging themes in contemporary masculinity: inclusivity (supporting gender, racial, and sexual equality), emotional intimacy (encouraging closer relationships and emotional expression among men), physicality (promoting non-sexual physical contact like hugging), and resistance (rejecting violence and risk-taking while embracing caregiving and work-life balance).

However, these changes may create new challenges. While contemporary masculinity is generally less restrictive, changes in norms can generate stress or conflict among individuals who have internalized traditional expectations, potentially contributing to gender role strain (Levant and Wong, 2017). Future research could examine how contemporary masculinities affect outcomes for both men and women, investigate how tensions between traditional and

contemporary masculinities manifest across different social contexts, and develop better measurement tools for tracking these evolving norms.

5 Stylized facts from global data

In the previous sections, we described how understanding various gendered patterns in economic, social, and political outcomes may be enriched by recognizing that masculinity norms may also shape these behaviors and attitudes. Much of the literature cited in this review implicitly or explicitly references masculinity norms, yet these norms are rarely measured directly.

This section summarizes findings based on masculinity data we collected in 70 countries through the Global Masculinity Survey (De Haas et al. 2025 and Baranov et al. 2025). We measure adherence to masculinity norms using a subset of questions from the Conformity to Masculinity Norms Inventory (CMNI), introduced in Section 2.3. We focus on five core dimensions of masculinity that reinforce male dominance, particularly over women and non-conforming men (henceforth, CMNI-5): *Importance of Winning* (“Winning is the most important thing”), *Violence* (“Sometimes violent action is necessary”), *Help Avoidance* (“It bothers me when I have to ask for help”), *Control Over Women* (“I love it when men are in charge of women”), and *Disdain for Homosexuals* (“It is important to me that people think I am heterosexual”).

To complement the measurement of adherence to masculinity norms, we also measure normative beliefs about the male role (henceforth, Normative Masculinity Index) in the following five dimensions: *Importance of Winning* (“Men should be aggressive and competitive to get ahead”), *Violence* (“Men should use violence to get respect if necessary”), *Help Avoidance* (“Men should figure out their personal problems on their own without asking others for help”), *Risk-Taking* (“It is important for a man to take risks, even if he might get hurt”), and *Emotional Control* (“Men should act strong even if they feel scared or nervous inside”).

We asked both men and women to rate their agreement with each statement on a 4-point Likert scale. We then constructed the CMNI-5 and Normative Masculinity Index so that higher scores indicate greater adherence to masculinity norms and stronger normative beliefs, respectively. We also elicit normative expectations about help avoidance by asking respondents to predict the percentage of adult men and women in their country that agree or strongly agree with “Men should figure out their personal problems on their own without asking others for help”.²³ Finally, we measure personal norms about women’s roles and relative position in society, which we refer to as “traditional gender roles norms” using a standard battery of questions frequently used by economists (e.g., “A woman should do most of the household chores even if the husband is not working”).

These new data show that masculinity norms vary widely within and across countries, and the following five stylized facts emerge:

²³See De Haas et al. (2025) and Baranov et al. (2025) for more information on the data collection process, sampling, and further details on how we built each index.

1. **Gender differences.** Men display greater adherence to masculinity norms than women in every country (Figure 1). Similarly, men have more restrictive normative beliefs about the male role than women (Figure A1).
2. **Age patterns.** Adherence to masculinity norms and endorsement of related normative beliefs follow distinct age patterns among men.²⁴ Adherence declines steadily with age, whereas endorsement of normative beliefs rises through early adulthood, peaking around age 30, before gradually declining. Although a substantial gap exists between adherence and beliefs in young adulthood, this gap narrows over time and disappears entirely by age 60 (Figure 2).²⁵
3. **Masculinity vs. gender roles norms.** Masculinity norms correlate positively with traditional gender roles norms, but more than half of the variation in masculinity norms remains unaccounted for by gender roles norms (see Figure 1 in De Haas et al. 2025).
4. **Masculinity norms predict behaviors.** Masculinity norms predict behaviors related to health, economics and politics, even when controlling for traditional gender roles norms. For example, a one standard deviation increase in the CMNI-5 score is associated with a 4.4 percentage point increase in the willingness to work more. In health, dominance masculinity norms predict greater risk taking and poorer mental health. In politics, adherence to masculinity norms predicts support for strongman leadership (De Haas et al., 2025).
5. **Misperceived norms.** Across countries, the majority of men and women overestimate others' support for masculinity norms. Moreover, 84% of countries in our survey exhibit pluralistic ignorance, i.e, a situation in which people perceive the minority view to be the majority view (Baranov et al., 2025).

These stylized facts demonstrate that masculinity norms operate distinctly from traditional gender roles, are predictive of important economic behaviors, and may persist partly through systematic misperceptions, highlighting both the scope for policy intervention and the mechanisms through which change might occur. Additionally, they motivate some of the questions for future research that we discuss in the next section.

6 Conclusions

In this review, we have argued that masculinity norms represent an important but underexplored dimension of economic behavior. Drawing on insights from evolutionary biology, anthropology, psychology, and sociology, we discussed how the study of masculinity norms in

²⁴Cross-sectional data on masculinity norms, like ours, cannot disentangle age versus cohort effects.

²⁵To enable direct comparison between adherence and normative beliefs, we restrict both indices to the three items that cover the same domains: help avoidance, importance of winning, and acceptance of violence.

economics can help explain persistent economic puzzles: why men avoid certain occupations despite unemployment, why workplace cultures resist family-friendly policies, why economic shocks disproportionately affect men's mental health and political attitudes, and why gender gaps in education and health persist despite policy interventions. We have discussed how masculinity norms can spread through institutional socialization, generational transmission, as well as peer networks, and often persist through systematic misperceptions about social expectations. Lastly, using novel data from 70 countries, we documented five key stylized facts: universal gender differences in adherence to masculinity norms, declining adherence with age, partial overlap with gender role norms, strong behavioral predictive power, and widespread pluralistic ignorance.

Looking ahead, we propose three research priorities. First, we encourage economists to more explicitly incorporate masculinity norms when studying men's socioeconomic outcomes and gender gaps. For example, research could examine the causal role of masculinity norms in shaping occupational sorting, the division of labor within the household, men's and women's demand for health services, and political attitudes. Economists could also work closely with policymakers to design and evaluate policies aiming at improving men's outcomes in domains where gender gaps favor women, and improve women's outcomes through, for example, programs to combat intimate partner violence. Second, future research could explore the social and historical paths of transmission of masculinity norms. How do masculinity norms spread through peer networks, families, and organizations? When and how do they change over the life course? Research could also investigate how women reinforce masculinity norms, for example through preferences in the dating market. Third, new research could expand the measurement of masculinity norms to incorporate modern dimensions of masculinity. Further measurement can also deepen our understanding of which dimensions of masculinity norms are more common and impact behaviors differently across contexts. Because masculinity is relational and situation-dependent, future research could examine when and how men enact masculine behaviors, particularly in response to threats to their status or identity.

References

- Abou Daher, C., Field, E., Swanson, K., and Vyborny, K. (2025). Drivers of Change: Employment Responses to the Lifting of the Saudi Female Driving Ban. *American Economic Review*. Forthcoming.
- Adams-Prassl, A., Huttunen, K., Nix, E., and Zhang, N. (2024). Violence Against Women at Work. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 139(2):937–991.
- Adda, J. and Fawaz, Y. (2020). The Health Toll of Import Competition. *The Economic Journal*, 130(630):1501–1540.
- Addis, M. E. and Mahalik, J. R. (2003). Men, Masculinity, and the Contexts of Help Seeking. *American Psychologist*, 58(1):5–14.
- Agostinelli, F., Doepke, M., Sorrenti, G., and Zilibotti, F. (2025). A Stairway to Success: How Parenting Shapes Culture and Social Stratification. Working Paper 33963, National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Aguiar, M., Bils, M., Charles, K. K., and Hurst, E. (2021). Leisure Luxuries and the Labor Supply of Young Men. *Journal of Political Economy*, 129(2):337–382.
- Aguiar, M. and Hurst, E. (2007). Measuring Trends in Leisure: The Allocation of Time Over Five Decades. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 122(3):969–1006.
- Aizer, A. (2010). The Gender Wage Gap and Domestic Violence. *American Economic Review*, 100(4):1847–59.
- Akerlof, G. A. and Kranton, R. E. (2000). Economics and Identity. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 115(3):715–753.
- Akerlof, R. (2016). “we thinking” and its consequences. *American Economic Review*, 106(5):415–19.
- Alger, I. (2021). On the Evolution of Male Competitiveness. *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, (190):228–254.
- Alger, I., Hooper, P. L., Cox, D., Stieglitz, J., and Kaplan, H. S. (2020). Paternal Provisioning Results From Ecological Change. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 117(20):10746–10754.
- Amaral, S., Borker, G., Fiala, N., Kumar, A., Prakash, N., and Sviatschi, M. M. (2025). Sexual Harassment in Public Spaces and Police Patrols: Experimental Evidence from Urban India. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*. Forthcoming.

- Amorim, G., Britto, D., Fonseca, A. d. A., and Sampaio, B. (2023). Job Loss, Unemployment Insurance and Health: Evidence From Brazil. *BAFFI CAREFIN Centre Research Paper*, (192).
- Anderson, S. (2025). Gender Biased Norms. Technical report, CEPR Discussion Paper No. 20211.
- Autor, D., Dorn, D., and Hanson, G. (2019). When Work Disappears: Manufacturing Decline and the Falling Marriage Market Value of Young Men. *American Economic Review: Insights*, 1(2):161–178.
- Autor, D. H., Duggan, M. G., and Lyle, D. S. (2011). Battle Scars? The Puzzling Decline in Employment and Rise in Disability Receipt among Vietnam Era Veterans. *American Economic Review*, 101(3):339–44.
- Baranov, V., Cameron, L., Contreras Suarez, D., and Thibout, C. (2021). Theoretical Underpinnings and Meta-Analysis of the Effects of Cash Transfers on Intimate Partner Violence in Low- and Middle-Income Countries. *The Journal of Development Studies*, 57(1):1–25.
- Baranov, V., De Haas, R., and Grosjean, P. (2023). Men. Male-Biased Sex Ratios and Masculinity Norms: Evidence from Australia’s Colonial Past. *Journal of Economic Growth*, pages 1–58.
- Baranov, V., De Haas, R., Grosjean, P., and Matavelli, I. (2025). Misperceived Masculinity Norms: Evidence From 32 Countries. Working paper. Unpublished manuscript.
- Barker, G., Hayes, C., Heilman, B., and Reichert, M. (2023). The State of American Men: From Crisis and Confusion to Hope. *Washington, DC: Equimundo*.
- Becker, A. (2021). Shamed to Death: Social Image Concerns and War Participation. Technical report, University College London.
- Becker, A. (2025). On the Origins of Restricting Women’s Promiscuity. *Review of Economic Studies*, 92(4):2303–2329.
- Bem, S. L. (1981). *Bem Sex Role Inventory: Professional Manual*. Consulting Psychologists Press, Palo Alto, CA.
- Bénabou, R. and Tirole, J. (2006). Incentives and Prosocial Behavior. *American Economic Review*, 96(5):1652–1678.
- Berdahl, J. L., Cooper, M., Glick, P., Livingston, R. W., and Williams, J. C. (2018). Work as a Masculinity Contest. *Journal of Social Issues*, 74(3):422–448.
- Bernhardt, A., Field, E., Pande, R., Rigol, N., Schaner, S., and Troyer-Moore, C. (2018). Male Social Status and Women’s Work. In *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, volume 108, pages 363–367.

- Bernheim, B. D. (1994). A Theory of Conformity. *Journal of Political Economy*, 102(5):841–877.
- Bertrand, M., Kamenica, E., and Pan, J. (2015). Gender Identity and Relative Income Within Households. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 130(2):571–614.
- Bicchieri, C. (2017). *Norms in the Wild: How to Diagnose, Measure, and Change Social Norms*. Oxford University Press, New York, NY.
- Blattman, C., Jamison, J. C., and Sheridan, M. (2017). Reducing Crime and Violence: Experimental Evidence from Cognitive Behavioral Therapy in Liberia. *American Economic Review*, 107(4):1165–1206.
- Blau, F. D. and Kahn, L. M. (2017). The Gender Wage Gap: Extent, Trends, and Explanations. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 55(3):789–865.
- Bosson, J. K., Vandello, J. A., Burnaford, R. M., Weaver, J. R., and Arzu Wasti, S. (2009). Precarious Manhood and Displays of Physical Aggression. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 35(5):623–634.
- Brenøe, A. A., Eyibak, Z., Heursen, L., Ranehill, E., and Weber, R. A. (2024). Gender Identity and Economic Decision Making. *Working Paper*, (2024: 6).
- Brescoll, V. L. and Uhlmann, E. L. (2008). Can an Angry Woman Get Ahead? Status Conferral, Gender, and Expression of Emotion in the Workplace. *Psychological Science*, 19(3):268–275.
- Bursztyn, L., Egorov, G., and Jensen, R. (2018). Cool to be Smart or Smart to be Cool? Understanding Peer Pressure in Education. *Review of Economic Studies*, 86(4):1487–1526.
- Bursztyn, L., González, A. L., and Yanagizawa-Drott, D. (2020). Misperceived Social Norms: Women Working Outside the Home in Saudi Arabia. *American Economic Review*, 110(10):2997–3029.
- Bursztyn, L. and Jensen, R. (2017). Social Image and Economic Behavior in the Field: Identifying, Understanding, and Shaping Social Pressure. *Annual Review of Economics*, 9:131–153.
- Buser, T., Niederle, M., and Oosterbeek, H. (2014). Gender, Competitiveness, and Career Choices. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 129(3):1409–1447.
- Bütikofer, A., Figlio, D. N., Karbownik, K., Kuzawa, C. W., and Salvanes, K. G. (2019). Evidence that Prenatal Testosterone Transfer from Male Twins Reduces the Fertility and Socioeconomic Success of their Female Co-Twins. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America*, 116(14):6749–6753.
- Butler, J. (1990). *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*. Routledge, New York.

- Buzard, K., Gee, L. K., and Stoddard, O. (2025). Who You Gonna Call? Gender Inequality in External Demands for Parental Involvement. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, pages 1–10.
- Cagé, J., Dagorret, A., Grosjean, P., and Jha, S. (2023). Heroes and Villains: The Effects of Heroism on Autocratic Values and Nazi Collaboration in France. *American Economic Review*, 113(7):1888–1932.
- Campbell, A. (2007). Sex Differences in Aggression. *Oxford Handbook of Evolutionary Psychology*, pages 365–382.
- Cao, Y., Enke, B., Falk, A., Giuliano, P., and Nunn, N. (2021). Herding, Warfare, and a Culture of Honor: Global Evidence. Working Paper 29250, National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Card, D., Cardoso, A. R., and Kline, P. (2016). Bargaining, Sorting, and the Gender Wage Gap: Quantifying the Impact of Firms on the Relative Pay of Women. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 131(2):633–686.
- Card, D. and Dahl, G. B. (2011). Family Violence and Football: The Effect of Unexpected Emotional Cues on Violent Behavior. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 126(1):103–143.
- Carré, J. M. and Mehta, P. H. (2018). Testosterone and Aggression: A Dual-Hormone Perspective on the Expression of Aggressive Behavior. *Hormones and Behavior*, 104:8–18.
- Carrigan, T., Connell, B., and Lee, J. (1985). Toward a New Sociology of Masculinity. *Theory and Society*, 14(5):551–604.
- Case, A. and Deaton, A. (2020). *Deaths of Despair and the Future of Capitalism*. Princeton University Press Princeton, NJ.
- Cassar, A. and Zhang, Y. J. (2022). The Competitive Woman: Evolutionary Insights and Cross-Cultural Evidence Into Finding the Femina Economica. *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, 197:447–471.
- Cavanagh, A., Wilson, C. J., Kavanagh, D. J., and Caputi, P. (2017). Differences in the Expression of Symptoms in Men Versus Women with Depression: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis. *Harvard Review of Psychiatry*, 25(1):29–38.
- Che, Y., Xu, X., and Zhang, Y. (2018). Chinese Import Competition, Crime, and Government Transfers in US. *Journal of Comparative Economics*, 46(2):544–567.
- Coates, J. M. and Herbert, J. (2008). Endogenous Steroids and Financial Risk Taking on a London Trading Floor. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 105(16):6167–6172.

- Cohen, D., Nisbett, R. E., Bowdle, B. F., and Schwarz, N. (1996). Insult, Aggression, and the Southern Culture of Honor: An “Experimental Ethnography.” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 70(5):945–59.
- Connell, R. and Messerschmidt, J. W. (2005). *Masculinities*. University of California Press, Berkeley, 2nd edition.
- Connor, S., Edvardsson, K., Fisher, C., and Spelten, E. (2021). Perceptions and Interpretation of Contemporary Masculinities in Western Culture: A Systematic Review. *American Journal of Men’s Health*, 15(6):15579883211061009.
- Cueva, C., Roberts, R. E., Spencer, T., Rani, N., Tempest, M., Tobler, P. N., Herbert, J., and Rustichini, A. (2015). Cortisol and Testosterone Increase Financial Risk Taking and May Destabilize Markets. *Scientific Reports*, 5:11206.
- Cullen, Z. and Perez-Truglia, R. (2023). The Old Boys’ Club: Schmoozing and the Gender Gap. *American Economic Review*, 113(7):1703–40.
- D’Acunto, F. (2020). Identity and Choice Under Risk. Working paper, Carroll School of Management, Boston College.
- Dahl, G. B., Kotsadam, A., and Rooth, D.-O. (2021). Does Integration Change Gender Attitudes? The Effect of Randomly Assigning Women to Traditionally Male Teams. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 136(2):987–1030.
- Dancygier, R., Egami, N., Jamal, A., and Rischke, R. (2022). Hate crimes and gender imbalances: fears over mate competition and violence against refugees. *American Journal of Political Science*, 66(2):501–515.
- Darwin, C. (1871). *The Descent of Man and Selection in Relation to Sex*. London, UK: John Murray.
- De Haas, R., Baranov, V., Matavelli, I., and Grosjean, P. (2025). Masculinity Around the World. Technical report, CEPR Discussion Paper No. 19493.
- Del Boca, D., Flinn, C., and Wiswall, M. (2014). Household Choices and Child Development. *Review of Economic Studies*, 81(1):137–185.
- Delavande, A., Del Bono, E., Holford, A., and Nolen, P. J. (2024). Less macho, more mellow: The malleability of competitiveness. SSRN Electronic Journal. Available at <https://ssrn.com/abstract=4833785>. DOI: 10.2139/ssrn.4833785.
- Delfino, A. (2024). Breaking Gender Barriers: Experimental Evidence on Men in Pink-Collar Jobs. *American Economic Review*, 114(6):1816–1853.

- Dix-Carneiro, R., Soares, R. R., and Ulyssea, G. (2018). Economic Shocks and Crime: Evidence from the Brazilian Trade Liberalization. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 10(4):158–195.
- Dizon-Ross, R. and Jayachandran, S. (2022). Dads and Daughters: Disentangling Altruism and Investment Motives for Spending on Children. University of Chicago, Becker Friedman Institute for Economics Working Paper No. 2022-51. Available at <https://ssrn.com/abstract=4076309>. DOI: 10.2139/ssrn.4076309.
- Dossi, G., Figlio, D., Giuliano, P., and Sapienza, P. (2021). The Family Origin of the Math Gender Gap Is a White Affluent Phenomenon. *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, 111:179–83.
- Eisenegger, C., Naef, M., Bächtiger, R., and Fehr, E. (2011). The Role of Testosterone in Social Interaction. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 15(6):263–271.
- Ertola Navajas, G., López Villalba, P. A., Rossi, M. A., and Vazquez, A. (2022). The Long-Term Effect of Military Conscription on Personality and Beliefs. *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 104(1):133–141.
- Farre, L., Felfe, C., Gonzalez, L., and Schneider, P. (2023). Changing Gender Norms Across Generations: Evidence from a Paternity Leave Reform. IZA Discussion Paper No. 16341. Available at <https://ssrn.com/abstract=4526266>. Available at SSRN.
- Fehr, E. and Gächter, S. (2002). Altruistic Punishment in Humans. *Nature*, 415(6868):137–140.
- Ferrant, G., Pesando, L. M., and Nowacka, K. (2014). Unpaid Care Work: The Missing Link in the Analysis of Gender Gaps in Labour Outcomes. *Boulogne Billancourt: OECD Development Center*, 20.
- Fleming, P. J. and Agnew-Brune, C. (2015). Current Trends in the Study of Gender Norms and Health Behaviors. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 5:72–77.
- Folke, O. and Rickne, J. (2020). All the Single Ladies: Job Promotions and the Durability of Marriage. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 12(1):260–287.
- Fortin, N. M., Oreopoulos, P., and Phipps, S. (2015). Leaving Boys Behind: Gender Disparities in High Academic Achievement. *Journal of Human Resources*, 50(3):549–579.
- Fryer Jr, R. G. and Levitt, S. D. (2010). An Empirical Analysis of the Gender Gap in Mathematics. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 2(2):210–240.
- Galiani, S., Rossi, M. A., and Schargrodsky, E. (2011). Conscription and Crime: Evidence from the Argentine Draft Lottery. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 3(2):119–36.

- GBD 2013 (2015). Global, Regional, and National Age–Sex Specific All-Cause and Cause-Specific Mortality for 240 Causes of Death, 1990–2013: A Systematic Analysis for the Global Burden of Disease Study 2013. *The Lancet*, 385(9963):117–171.
- Geniole, S. N., Bird, B. M., McVittie, J. S., Purcell, R. B., Archer, J., and Carré, J. M. (2020). Is Testosterone Linked to Human Aggression? A Meta-Analytic Examination of the Relationship Between Baseline, Dynamic, and Manipulated Testosterone on Human Aggression. *Hormones and Behavior*, 123(June 2019):104644.
- Gennaro, G. and Ash, E. (2022). Emotion and Reason in Political Language. *The Economic Journal*, 132(643):1037–1059.
- Gilmore, D. D. (1990). *Manhood in the Making: Cultural Concepts of Masculinity*. Yale University Press.
- Giuliano, P. (2018). Gender: A Historical Perspective. In Averett, S. L., Argys, L. M., and Hoffman, S. D., editors, *The Oxford Handbook of Women and the Economy*, number July 2017, pages 644–672. Oxford University Press.
- Giuliano, P. (2020). Gender and Culture. *Oxford Review of Economic Policy*, 36(4):944–961.
- Gneezy, U., Leonard, K. L., and List, J. A. (2009). Gender Differences in Competition: Evidence from a Matrilineal and a Patriarchal Society. *Econometrica*, 77(5):1637–1664.
- Goldin, C. (2014). A Pollution Theory of Discrimination: Male and Female Differences in Occupations and Earnings. In *Human Capital in History: The American Record*, pages 313–348. University of Chicago Press.
- Goldin, C. (2021). *Career and Family: Women’s Century-Long Journey toward Equity*. Princeton University Press.
- Goldin, C. (2024). Nobel Lecture: An Evolving Economic Force. *American Economic Review*, 114(6):1515–1539.
- Goldin, C., Katz, L. F., and Kuziemko, I. (2006). The Homecoming of American College Women: The Reversal of the College Gender Gap. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 20(4):133–156.
- Grosjean, P. (2014). A History of Violence: The Culture of Honor and Homicide in the US South. *Journal of the European Economic Association*, 12(5):1285–1316.
- Grosjean, P. (2021). *Patriarcapitalisme: En Finir avec les Inégalités Femmes/Hommes dans l’Économie*. Seuil.

- Guadalupe, M., Pollene, D., and Snellman, K. (2025). Masculinity, Diversity and Inclusion at Work: Evidence from Research Institutions. Working paper, INSEAD. Unpublished manuscript.
- Guarnieri, E. and Tur-Prats, A. (2023). Cultural Distance and Conflict-Related Sexual Violence. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 138(3):1817–1861.
- Hancock, K., Lafortune, J., and Low, C. (2025). Winning the Bread and Baking it Too: Gendered Frictions in the Allocation of Home Production. Working Paper 33393, National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Heller, S. B., Shah, A. K., Guryan, J., Ludwig, J., Mullainathan, S., and Pollack, H. A. (2017). Thinking, Fast and Slow? Some Field Experiments to Reduce Crime and Dropout in Chicago. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 132(1):1–54.
- Henrich, J., Boyd, R., and Richerson, P. J. (2012). The Puzzle of Monogamous Marriage. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, 367:657–669.
- Henrich, J. and Gil-White, F. J. (2001). The Evolution of Prestige: Freely Conferred Deference as a Mechanism for Enhancing the Benefits of Cultural Transmission. *Evolution and Human Behavior*, 22(3):165–196.
- Hrdy, S. B. (2011). *Mothers and Others: The Evolutionary Origins of Mutual Understanding*. Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA.
- Hrdy, S. B. (2024). *Father Time: A Natural History of Men and Babies*. Princeton University Press.
- Inglehart, R. and Norris, P. (2019). *Cultural Backlash: Trump, Brexit, and Authoritarian Populism*. Cambridge University Press.
- Jayachandran, S. (2015). The Roots of Gender Inequality in Developing Countries. *Annual Review of Economics*, 7(1):63–88.
- Katz, J. (2016). *Man Enough?: Donald Trump, Hillary Clinton, and the Politics of Presidential Masculinity*. Interlink Books.
- Kimmel, M. (2017). *Angry White Men: American Masculinity at the End of an Era*. Hachette UK.
- Kimmel, M. S. (2012). *The History of Men: Essays on the History of American and British Masculinities*. State University of New York Press.
- Kimmel, M. S., Hearn, J., and Connell, R. W. (2004). *Handbook of Studies on Men and Masculinities*. Sage Publications.

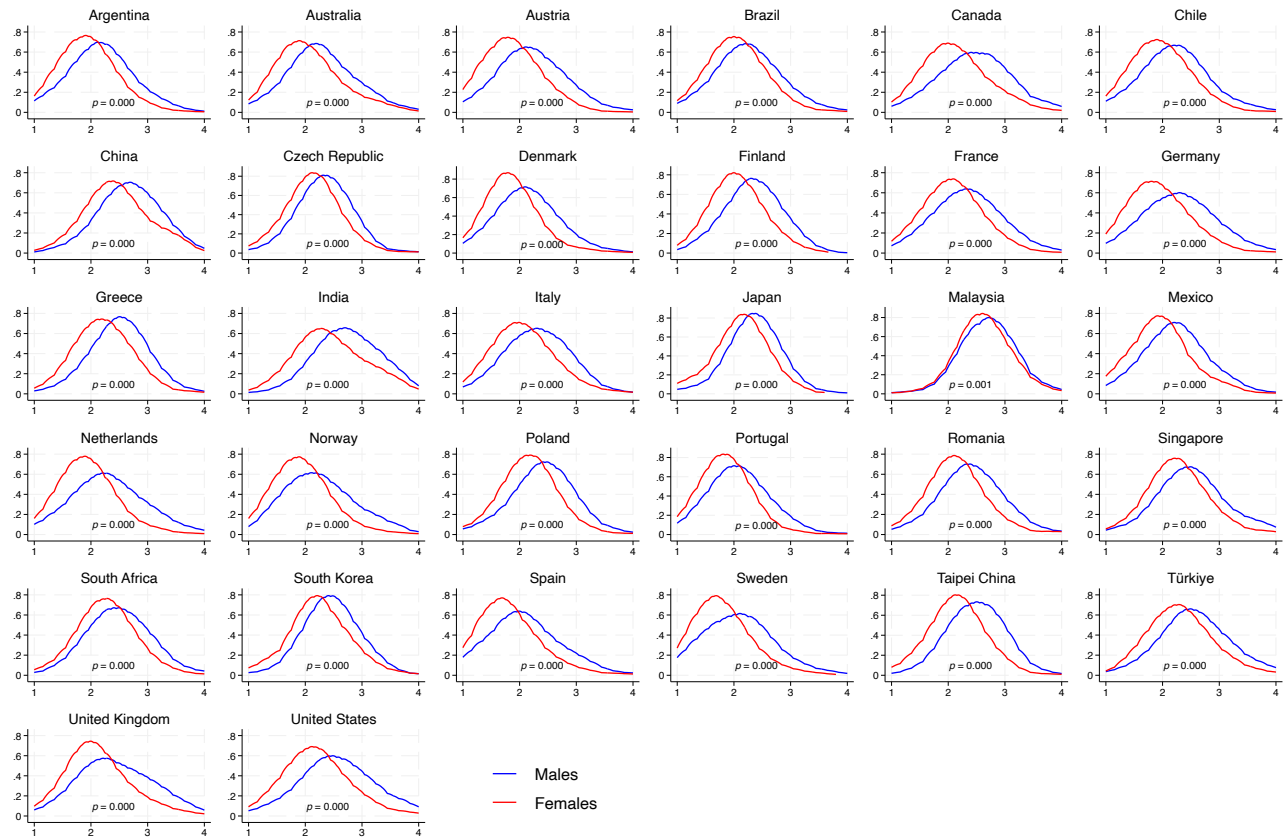
- Kitagawa, R., Kanayama, H., and Kawata, Y. (2025). Supervisor Accuracy in Subjective Evaluations and Employee Careers. Discussion paper, Research Institute of Economy, Trade and Industry (RIETI). Forthcoming.
- Klassen, A. J. (2022). *The Great Reset: Public Opinion, Populism, and the Pandemic*. Bennett Institute for Public Policy at the University of Cambridge.
- Kleven, H., Landais, C., and Leite-Mariante, G. (2024). The Child Penalty Atlas. *Review of Economic Studies*. Forthcoming.
- Kleven, H., Landais, C., and Søgaaard, J. E. (2019). Children and Gender Inequality: Evidence from Denmark. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 11(4):181–209.
- Levant, R. F. and Fischer, J. (1998). The Male Role Norms Inventory. In Davis, C. M., Yarber, W. H., Bauserman, R., Schreer, G., and Davis, S. L., editors, *Sexuality-related measures: A compendium*, pages 469–472. Sage, Thousand Oaks, CA, 2nd edition.
- Levant, R. F. and Wong, Y. (2017). *The Psychology of Men and Masculinities*. American Psychological Association.
- Lippa, R. A. (2016). Biological Influences on Masculinity. In Wong, Y. J. and Wester, S. R., editors, *APA Handbook of Men and Masculinities*, chapter 9, pages 187–209. American Psychological Association, Washington, DC.
- Lundberg, S. (2020). Educational Gender Gaps. *Southern Economic Journal*, 87(2):416–439.
- Lundberg, S. (2024). The Economics of Gender Norms. *Scottish Journal of Political Economy*, page e12407.
- Mahalik, J., Locke, B., Ludlow, L., Diemer, M., Scott, R., Gottfried, M., and Freitas, G. (2003). Development of the Conformity to Masculine Norms Inventory. *Psychology of Men and Masculinity*, 4(1):3–25.
- Mahalik, J. R. and Rochlen, A. B. (2005). Men’s Gender Role Conflict and Use of Psychological Defenses. *Psychology of Men & Masculinity*, 6(2):109–115.
- Mahalik, J. R. and Rochlen, A. B. (2006). Men’s Likely Responses to Clinical Depression: What Are They and Do Masculinity Norms Predict Them? *Sex Roles*, 55:659–667.
- Matavelli, I. (2025). We Don’t Talk About Boys: An Experiment on Masculinity Norms in Brazil. Unpublished manuscript.
- Michniewicz, K. S., Vandello, J. A., and Bosson, J. K. (2014). Men’s (Mis)perceptions of the Gender Threatening Consequences of Unemployment. *Sex Roles*, 70:88–97.

- Niederle, M. and Vesterlund, L. (2010). Explaining the Gender Gap in Math Test Scores: The Role of Competition. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 24(2):129–144.
- Niederle, M. and Vesterlund, L. (2011). Gender and Competition. *Annual Review of Economics*, 3(1):601–630.
- Nollenberger, N., Rodríguez-Planas, N., and Sevilla, A. (2016). The Math Gender Gap: The Role of Culture. In *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, volume 106, pages 257–261.
- OECD (2019). *PISA 2018 Results (Volume II): Where All Students Can Succeed*. PISA. OECD Publishing, Paris.
- Olivetti, C., Pan, J., and Petrongolo, B. (2024). The Evolution of Gender in the Labor Market. In *Handbook of Labor Economics*, volume 5, pages 619–677. Elsevier.
- Olivetti, C. and Petrongolo, B. (2017). The Economic Consequences of Family Policies: Lessons from a Century of Legislation in High-Income Countries. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 31(1):205–230.
- Pan, J. (2015). Gender Segregation in Occupations: The Role of Tipping and Social Interactions. *Journal of Labor Economics*, 33(2):365–408.
- Paxton, P. and Hughes, M. M. (2017). *Women, Politics, and Power: A Global Perspective*. Sage Publications, Thousand Oaks, CA, 3rd edition.
- Petts, R. J., Shafer, K. M., and Essig, L. (2018). Does Adherence to Masculine Norms Shape Fathering Behavior? *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 80(3):704–720.
- Pleck, J. H. (1981). *The Myth of Masculinity*. MIT Press, Cambridge, MA.
- Pleck, J. H. (2010). Fatherhood and Masculinity. In Lamb, M. E., editor, *The Role of the Father in Child Development*, pages 27–57. John Wiley Sons, Inc., 5th edition.
- Recalde, M. P. and Vesterlund, L. (2023). Gender Differences in Negotiation: Can Interventions Reduce the Gap? *Annual Review of Economics*, 15(1):633–657.
- Rice, S. M., Fallon, B. J., Aucote, H. M., and Möller-Leimkühler, A. M. (2013). Development and Preliminary Validation of the Male Depression Risk Scale: Furthering the Assessment of Depression in Men. *Journal of Affective Disorders*, 151(3):950–958.
- Salk, R. H., Hyde, J. S., and Abramson, L. Y. (2017). Gender Differences in Depression in Representative National Samples: Meta-analyses of Diagnoses and Symptoms. *Psychological Bulletin*, 143(8):783–822.

- Sapienza, P., Zingales, L., and Maestripieri, D. (2009). Gender Differences in Financial Risk Aversion and Career Choices are Affected by Testosterone. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 106(36):15268–15273.
- Schünemann, J., Strulik, H., and Trimborn, T. (2017). The Gender Gap in Mortality: How Much is Explained by Behavior? *Journal of Health Economics*, 54:79–90.
- Seidler, Z. E., Rice, S. M., Ogrodniczuk, J. S., Oliffe, J. L., and Dhillon, H. M. (2018). Engaging Men in Psychological Treatment: A Scoping Review. *American Journal of Men's Health*, 12(6):1882–1900.
- Shah, M., Seager, J., Montalvao, J., and Goldstein, M. (2023). Sex, Power, and Adolescence: Intimate Partner Violence and Sexual Behaviors. Working Paper 31624, National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Sharma, K. (2023). Tackling Sexual Harassment: Short and Long-Run Experimental Evidence from India. Working paper. Unpublished manuscript.
- Shirzad, M., Yenokyan, G., Marcell, A. V., and Kaufman, M. R. (2024). Deaths of Despair-Associated Mortality Rates Globally: A 2000–2019 Sex-Specific Disparities Analysis. *Public Health*, 236:35–42.
- Spierings, N. and Zaslove, A. (2017). Gender, Populist Attitudes, and Voting: Explaining the Gender Gap in Voting for Populist Radical Right and Populist Radical Left Parties. *West European Politics*, 40(4):821–847.
- Thompson Jr, E. H. and Bennett, K. M. (2015). Measurement of Masculinity Ideologies: A (Critical) Review. *Psychology of Men & Masculinity*, 16(2):115–133.
- Thompson Jr, E. H. and Pleck, J. H. (1986). The Structure of Male Role Norms. *American Behavioral Scientist*, 29(5):531–543.
- Trivers, R. L. (1972). Parental Investment and Sexual Selection. In Campbell, B., editor, *Sexual Selection and the Descent of Man, 1871-1971*, pages 136–179. Aldine, Chicago.
- UNODC (2019). Global Study on Homicide: Homicide Trends, Patterns and Criminal Justice Response.
- Van Anders, S. M., Steiger, J., and Goldey, K. L. (2015). Effects of Gendered Behavior on Testosterone in Women and Men. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(45):13805–13810.

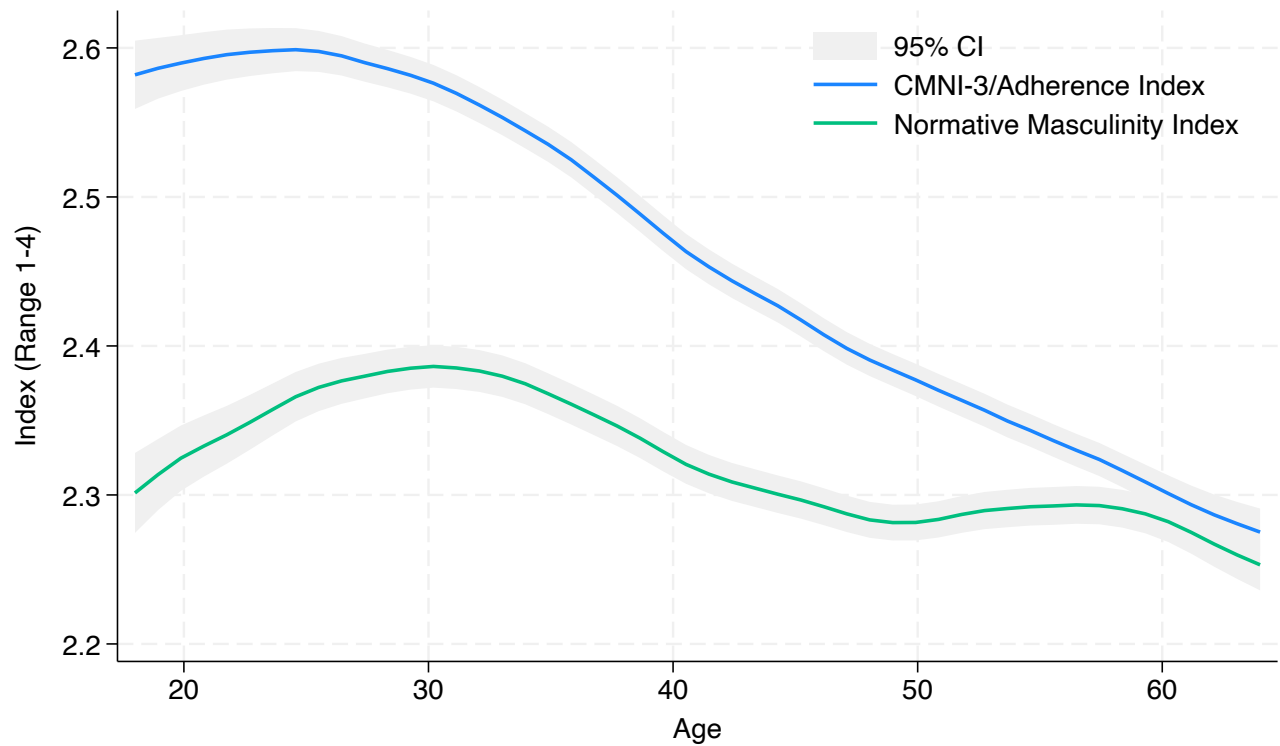
- Vandello, J. A. and Bosson, J. K. (2013). Hard Won and Easily Lost: A Review and Synthesis of Theory and Research on Precarious Manhood. *Psychology of Men & Masculinity*, 14(2):101–113.
- Vandello, J. A., Bosson, J. K., Cohen, D., Burnaford, R. M., and Weaver, J. R. (2008). Precarious Manhood. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 95(6):1325–39.
- Vescio, T. K. and Schermerhorn, N. E. (2021). Hegemonic Masculinity Predicts 2016 and 2020 Voting and Candidate Evaluations. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 118(2):e2020589118.
- Vigil, J. D. (1996). Street Baptism: Chicano Gang Initiation. *Human Organization*, 55(2):149–153.
- Walker, S., Grosjean, P., Cristia, A., and Delavande, A. (2025). HeforShe : Bargaining Power, Parental Beliefs, and Parental Investments. Working paper. Unpublished manuscript.
- Wedgwood, N., Connell, R., and Wood, J. (2023). Deploying Hegemonic Masculinity: A Study of Uses of the Concept in the Journal Psychology of Men & Masculinities. *Psychology of Men & Masculinities*, 24(2):83.
- Weisshaar, K. (2018). From Opt Out to Blocked Out: The Challenges for Labor Market Re-entry After Family-Related Employment Lapses. *American Sociological Review*, 83(1):34–60.
- Wong, Y. J., Ho, M.-H. R., Wang, S.-Y., and Miller, I. (2017). Meta-Analyses of the Relationship Between Conformity to Masculine Norms and Mental Health-Related Outcomes. *Journal of Counseling Psychology*, 64(1):80–93.
- Young, H. P. (2015). The Evolution of Social Norms. *Annual Review of Economics*, 7(1):359–387.
- Yuan, B., Gao, D., Yu, R., and Huang, Y. (2025). Unpacking the Link Between Hormonal Fluctuations and Risk-Taking: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis. *Neuroscience Biobehavioral Reviews*, 175:106215.

Figure 1: Distributions of adherence to masculinity norms (CMNI-5) by gender and country



Notes: Each panel displays the distribution of the 5-item CMNI, an index of adherence to masculinity norms based on [Mahalik et al. \(2003\)](#), as a kernel density by gender for each country. Further details about the survey and index construction can be found at [De Haas et al. \(2025\)](#). Total sample across the 32 countries is 41,679 males and 38,519 females. P-values reflect tests of gender differences in CMNI means within each country. *Data:* Global Masculinity Survey (online component).

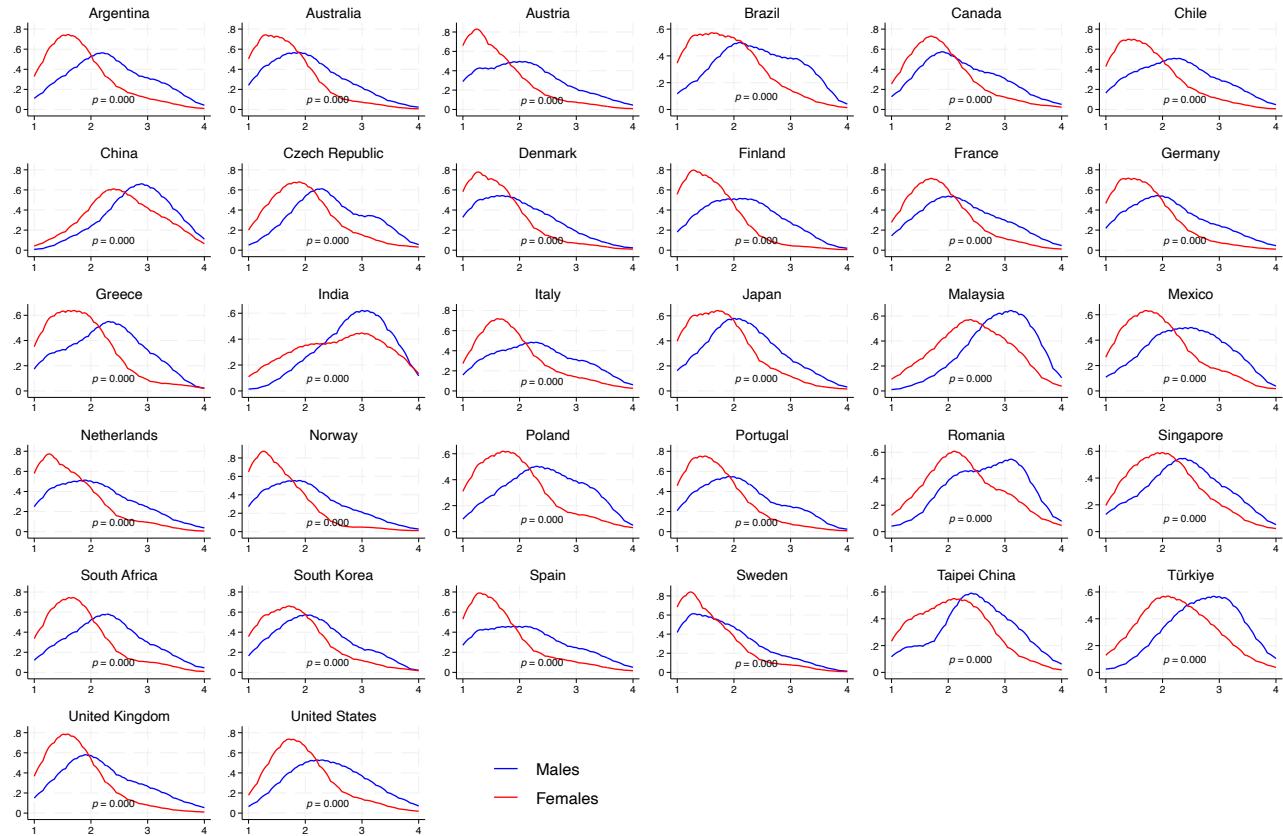
Figure 2: Adherence to and normative beliefs about masculinity norms by age



Notes: The figure displays the CMNI (3-item) and normative masculinity index (3-item) as a function of age in the male sample using local linear regression, with corresponding 95% confidence intervals. The three items in each index correspond to the domains of help avoidance, importance of winning, and violence. Both indices have been residualized to remove country fixed effects. Total sample across the 32 countries is 41,654 men for the CMNI 3-item and 41,803 men for the normative index 3-item. *Data:* Global Masculinity Survey (online component).

Appendix

Figure A1: Distributions of normative masculinity by gender and country



Notes: Each panel displays the distribution of the 5-item normative masculinity index as a kernel density by gender for each country. Total sample across the 32 countries is 41,823 males and 38,645 females. P-values reflect tests of gender differences in means within each country. *Data:* Global Masculinity Survey (online component).